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Credit - Drishti Ias

National Panchayati Raj Day 2026

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For Prelims: 73rd Constitutional Amendment , Panchayati Raj Institutions , Model Youth Gram Sabha Initiative , People's Plan Campaign , Panchayat NIRNAY , 15th Finance Commission, State Election Commission (SEC) , SabhaSaar , SVAMITVA Scheme , eGramSwaraj , Rashtriya Gram Swaraj Abhiyan (RGSA) , Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

For Mains: Decentralization and grassroots democracy in India, 73rd Constitutional Amendment: provisions and significance, Role of PRIs in rural development and governance

Source: PIB

Why in News?

India celebrated **National Panchayati Raj Day (NPRD)** on **24 th April 2026** , commemorating the enactment of the **73 rd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1992** , which granted constitutional status to **Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs)** , marking 33 years of this defining milestone in India's democratic journey.

Summary

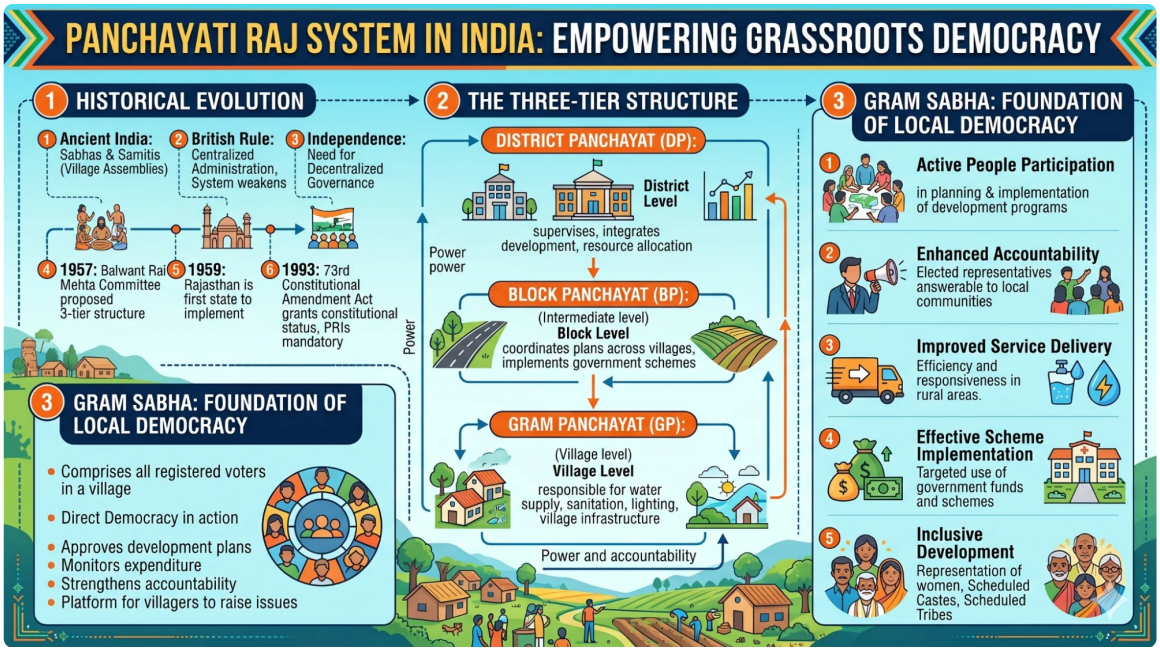
- **National Panchayati Raj Day 2026** marked 33 years of the 73 rd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1992, which gave constitutional status to Panchayati Raj Institutions and strengthened grassroots democracy in India.
- The system has expanded participatory governance through a three-tier structure and reservations, but continues to face challenges like fiscal dependency, weak devolution, capacity gaps, and parallel administrative structures.

What is the National Panchayati Raj Day?

- **Historical Background:** The day commemorates the institutionalization of the Panchayati Raj system in India through the **73 rd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1992.**
  - The Act came into force on **24th April 1993** , marking a defining moment in the history of decentralized political power in India.
- **First Celebration:** The first National Panchayati Raj Day was celebrated in 2010 under the leadership of

then-Prime Minister Manmohan Singh.

- **Objective:** To assess the progress of rural decentralization, interact with Gram Panchayat representatives, and recognize their outstanding contributions to rural development.
- **Theme for NPRD 2026:** The theme, “Sashakt Panchayat, Sarvangeen Vikas” (Empowered Panchayats, Holistic Development), focuses on **localising Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)** and strengthening digital governance through e-Gram Swaraj to achieve the vision of “ **Viksit Bharat” by 2047** .



What are the Key Provisions of the 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act (1992)?

- **Structural Additions to the Constitution: The 73rd CAA fundamentally altered India's federal structure by shifting it from a two-tier system (Centre and States) to a multi-level decentralized architecture , providing "practical shape" to Article 40 (Directive Principles of State Policy).**
  - **Part IX:** Inserted Articles 243 to 243-O, explicitly detailing the mechanics of rural local self-government.
  - **Eleventh Schedule:** Added to enumerate 29 functional items (e.g., land improvement, minor irrigation, rural electrification) designated for devolution to **Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs)** under **Article 243G** .
- **Institutionalization of Participatory Democracy : India has over 2.5 lakh Panchayats and 24.04 lakh elected representatives. Remarkably, women make up 49.75% of these representatives.**
  - **Gram Sabha (Article 243A):** Established as the foundational unit. Unlike the elected Panchayat, the **Gram Sabha** consists of *all registered voters* in a village, making it the only forum of direct, participatory democracy in the Indian constitutional scheme.
- **Three-Tier Architecture (Article 243B & 243C): Mandated a uniform three-tier system: Village, Intermediate (Block/Mandal), and District levels.**
  - **The Demographic Exception:** States with a population under **20 lakhs** are exempt from establishing the intermediate tier, preventing bureaucratic bloat in smaller states.
- **Electoral Mechanics:** All members at all three levels are chosen by **direct election** .

- However, to maintain structural cohesion, the chairpersons at the intermediate and district levels are elected **indirectly** from amongst the elected members.

- **Demographic Equity & Reservations (Article 243D):**
  - **SC/STs:** Reservation is strictly proportional to their demographic share in the Panchayat area across all three tiers.
  - **Women's Quota:** A **non-negotiable minimum of 33% (one-third)** of all seats and chairperson offices must be reserved for women.
    - This includes a one-third sub-quota within the SC/ST reserved seats.
- **Tenure Security and Dissolution Guardrails (Article 243E): Fixed a rigid five-year term .**
  - If a Panchayat is prematurely dissolved, elections must occur before the expiration of a six-month period.
  - A reconstituted Panchayat operates only for the *unexpired remainder* of the dissolved body's term, preventing states from manipulating dissolution to reset election cycles.
    - If the remainder is less than six months, elections are not mandatory.
- **Creation of Independent State-Level Watchdogs**
  - **State Election Commission (Article 243K):** Vested with the superintendence, direction, and control of electoral rolls and the conduct of PRI elections. To ensure autonomy, the **State Election Commissioner** has security of tenure equivalent to a High Court Judge.
  - **State Finance Commission (Article 243-I):** Mandated every five years to review PRI finances, recommend tax distribution between the State and Panchayats, and determine grants-in-aid, thereby institutionalizing financial devolution.

What are the Challenges facing the Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs)?

Fiscal Strangulation: The "Dependency Trap"

- **Dismal Own Source Revenue (OSR):** According to the **RBI's 2024 report on 'Finances of Panchayati Raj Institutions'** , PRIs generate a mere **1.1% of their total revenue** from local taxes and fees.
  - The Ministry of Panchayati Raj (MoPR) expert committee data further reveal that the national average for per capita OSR collected by Panchayats is a negligible **Rs 59 annually** .
- **Overwhelming Grant Dependency:** Approximately **95% of Panchayat revenue** comes from higher tiers of government (roughly 80% from Central grants and 15% from State grants).
  - In states with low OSR, like Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh, this dependency crosses 95%.
- **The "Tied Funds" Constraint:** While the **15 th Finance Commission** awarded substantial funds to Rural Local Bodies, **60% of these are "tied grants"** (mandated strictly for sanitation, drinking water, etc.).
  - This strips Gram Panchayats of the autonomy to prioritize local, context-specific developmental needs.
- **Reluctance and Ambiguity in Taxation:** Even where legally empowered, PRIs hesitate to levy property or water taxes due to proximity to voters (fear of political backlash).
- Furthermore, state laws often lack clarity on property valuation, rate revision, and taxation definitions, severely hindering OSR collection.

Administrative and Functional Erosion

- **Incomplete Activity Mapping:** State governments frequently devolve subjects on paper but retain control over the **actual budgeting and operational frameworks.**
  - Essential services (like solid waste management and drinking water) are managed by state line departments, meaning PRIs cannot levy user charges for them.
- **Proliferation of Parallel Bodies:** State governments frequently bypass PRIs by creating **Special Purpose Vehicles (SPVs) ,** parastatals, or line-department committees for executing schemes (e.g., rural infrastructure projects).
  - This fragments local governance and erodes the constitutional authority of the Gram Panchayat.
- **Resource Deficit over CPRs:** Common Property Resources (CPRs) like forests, grazing lands, and local water bodies remain largely under the control of state line departments, cutting off a vital potential revenue stream for Gram Panchayats.

Institutional and Structural Bottlenecks

- **Defunct State Finance Commissions (SFCs):** Article 243-I mandates the constitution of SFCs every five years to formalize revenue-sharing between the state and PRIs.
  - However, SFCs are routinely delayed, severely under-resourced, and their recommendations are frequently rejected or ignored by State Legislatures.
- **Human Resource and Capacity Deficit:** PRIs suffer from a severe shortage of technical and administrative staff (e.g., accountants, engineers).
  - Overburdened Panchayat officials lack the training required for complex tasks like tax assessment, spatial planning, and digital auditing via eGramSwaraj.
- **Social and Proxy Representation:** The pervasive **"Sarpanch Pati" syndrome** —where male relatives wield the actual executive power on behalf of elected women representatives—continues to undermine the 33% reservation mandate (Article 243D) and stifles genuine grassroots gender empowerment

India’s Initiatives Related to PRIs

- **SVAMITVA Scheme:** Launched in April 2021, it uses drones and **Geographical Information System (GIS)** to map inhabited village areas and issue property cards.
  - As of March 2026, surveys are complete in 3.29 lakh villages, and 2.65 crore property cards have been distributed.
- **SabhaSaar:** An AI-powered tool integrated with **Bhashini** that automatically transcribes and structures Gram Sabha meeting minutes in 23 regional languages. It is currently used by over 1 lakh Gram Panchayats.
- **eGramSwaraj:** A portal available in 22 languages for planning, financial management, and real-time payments and it is linked with the **Public Financial Management System.**
- **Gram Urja Swaraj:** A dashboard tracking renewable energy assets in real-time. It monitors solar, hydel, wind, and biogas usage across 2,080 Gram Panchayats.
- **Meri Panchayat App:** An m-Governance platform developed by **NIC** to improve citizen participation and accountability, aligned with the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).
- **Rashtriya Gram Swaraj Abhiyan (RGSA):** A scheme designed to build leadership and governance capabilities to meet SDGs.
- **Model Women-Friendly Gram Panchayat (MWFGP):** An initiative under **SDG Theme 9** aiming to develop one model women-friendly Panchayat per district, focusing on safety, rights, and inclusive governance.
- **Sashakt Panchayat–Netri Abhiyan:** A special interactive training module that has trained around 1.5 lakh Elected Women Representatives (EWRs) to enhance their leadership, communication, and negotiation skills.
- **Model Youth Gram Sabha (MYGS):** A program engaging Class 9 and 10 students from Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalayas and Eklavya Model Residential Schools in mock Gram Sabhas to foster participatory democracy among the youth.
- **Increased Finance Grants:** Funding for Rural Local Bodies jumped from Rs 2.36 lakh crore under the **15th Finance Commission (2021–26)** to nearly Rs 4.35 lakh crore under the **16th Finance Commission (2026–31).**
  - Grants are categorized into "untied" (for local needs) and "tied" (for basic services like water and sanitation) to balance flexibility with accountability.
  - **Union Budget** allocations for rural development have spiked by over 211% in the last decade, reaching Rs 2.73 lakh crore for 2026–27.
  - Funds are successfully converging with major initiatives like the **Viksit Bharat- G RAM G Act, 2025 , Jal Jeevan Mission , and Swachh Bharat Mission** to drastically improve rural infrastructure.

What Measures are Needed to Strengthen Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs)?

- **Granular Activity Mapping:** Replace broad, vague delegations of the 11th Schedule's 29 subjects with strict, granular "Activity Mapping."
  - Clearly delineate which specific tasks (e.g., primary school maintenance vs. teacher hiring) belong to the village, block, and district levels, eliminating overlap with state departments.
- **Dismantling Parallel Bodies:** State governments must abolish overlapping parastatals and Special

Purpose Vehicles (SPVs) that execute rural infrastructure projects. All funds and functionaries for rural development must be routed exclusively through PRIs.

- **Creation of a Panchayat Management Cadre:** Establish a dedicated, professional cadre of Panchayat Development Officers (PDOs), accountants, and rural engineers. This cadre should be accountable directly to the Gram Panchayat, not to the state bureaucracy (Block Development Officers).
- **Digital Integration & E-Governance:** Mandate the end-to-end use of **eGramSwaraj** and the **Public Financial Management System (PFMS)** for all Panchayat transactions. This ensures real-time auditing, reduces leakage, and builds state/central trust in local financial management.
- **Institutionalized Social Audits:** Adopt the **Meghalaya Model** by creating an independent Directorate of Social Audit. Social audits for all flagship schemes (**PMAY-G**) must be conducted by trained local facilitators independent of the Panchayat administration.
- **Curbing Proxy Representation ("Sarpanch Pati"):** Introduce stringent disqualification clauses for male relatives acting as proxies for elected women representatives. Couple this with specialized leadership and administrative training exclusively for elected women and SC/ST representatives.

Conclusion

- Panchayati Raj Institutions represent grassroots democracy in India, enabling participatory and inclusive governance aligned with local needs. They have strengthened accountability and responsiveness in rural areas, showing that national development depends on empowered villages.

Drishti Mains Question:

Q. “The success of Panchayati Raj depends more on devolution than on constitutional provisions.” Critically examine

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. **What is National Panchayati Raj Day?**
   Celebrated on 24 April to mark the implementation of the 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1992, promoting decentralized governance.
2. **What does Part IX of the Constitution deal with?**
   It covers Panchayati Raj Institutions (Articles 243–243O), defining structure, powers, and elections of PRIs.
3. **What is the role of the State Finance Commission (SFC)?**
   Constituted every 5 years under Article 243-I to recommend financial devolution and grants to PRIs.
4. **What is the major fiscal challenge of PRIs?**
   PRIs depend heavily on grants (around 95%) due to very low own source revenue (OSR).
5. **What is the “Sarpanch Pati” issue?**
   It refers to proxy representation where male relatives exercise power on behalf of elected women, undermining Article 243D.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/aSf9m4lvH_E**]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQ)

Prelims

Q1. Local self-government can be best explained as an exercise in (2017)

(a) Federalism

(b) Democratic decentralisation

(c) Administrative delegation

(d) Direct democracy

Ans: (b)

Q2. The fundamental object of the Panchayati Raj system is to ensure which among the following? (2015)

1. People’s participation in development
2. Political accountability
3. Democratic decentralisation
4. Financial mobilisation

Select the correct answer using the code given below

(a) 1, 2 and 3 only

(b) 2 and 4 only

(c) 1 and 3 only

(d) 1, 2, 3 and 4

Ans: (c)

Mains

Q1. Assess the importance of the Panchayat system in India as a part of local government. Apart from government grants, what sources can the Panchayats look out for financing developmental projects? (2018)

Q2. To what extent, in your opinion, has the decentralisation of power in India changed the governance landscape at the grassroots? (2022)

3rd Synchronised Nilgiri Tahr Survey

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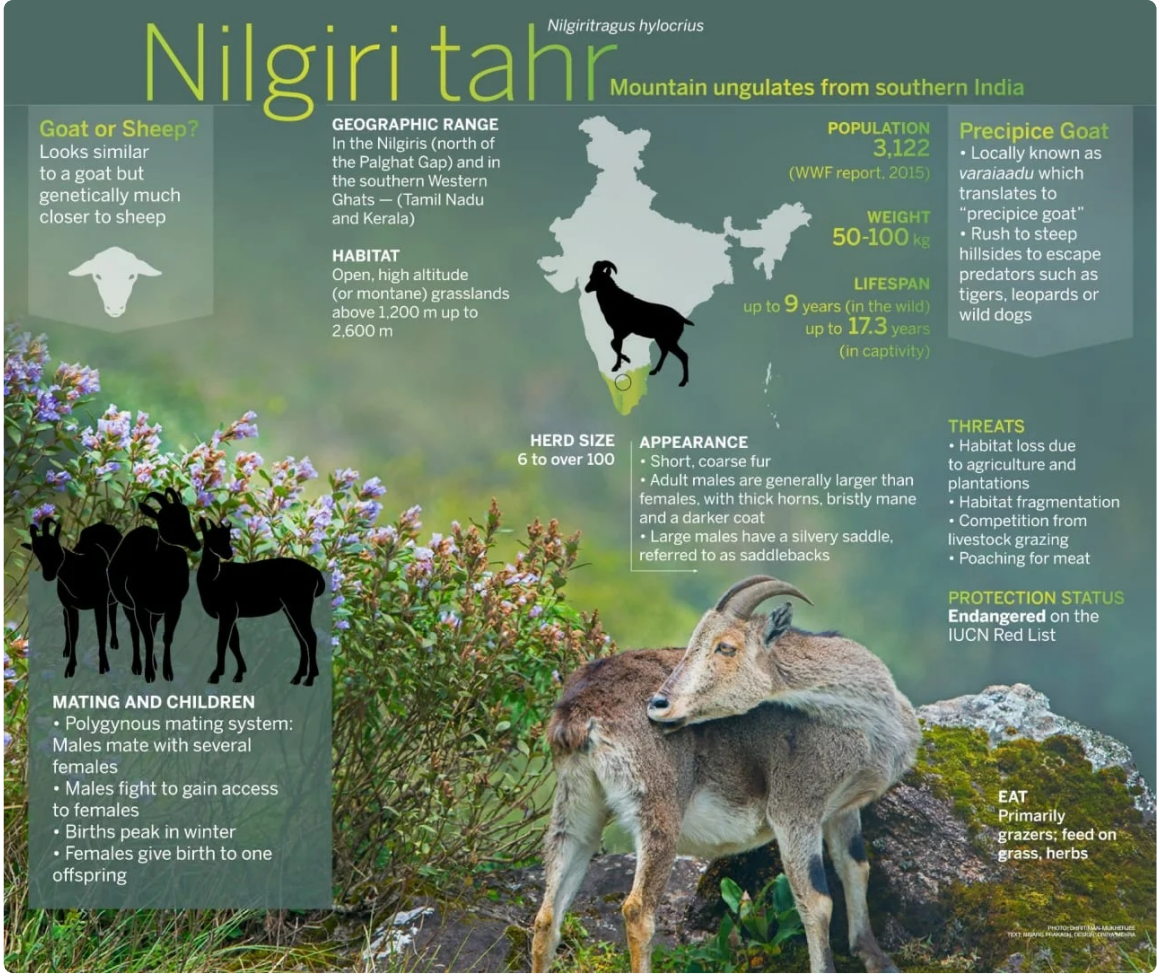
Source: TH

Recently, the **Tamil Nadu Forest Department launched the third synchronised Nilgiri Tahr survey** across the **Western Ghats** in coordination with Kerala.

- The survey ensures simultaneous counting across state boundaries to avoid duplication and improve accuracy, covering over 3,100 km across 14 forest divisions from **Ashambu Mottai (Kanniyakumari) to Tavalamalai (Gudalur).**
- Use of the **"Varudai" mobile app** with a supporting web-based system enables real-time data collection, GPS tracking, and standardised reporting, while participation of independent institutions such as the **International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN)** , **Botanical Survey of India** , and **Wildlife Trust of India** ensures scientific rigour and credibility.

Nilgiri Tahr

- **About:** Also known as Varayaadu or Nilgiri Ibex, it is a caprine ungulate **endemic to the Western Ghats** , specifically in Kerala and Tamil Nadu (where it is the state animal).
  - It inhabits **montane grasslands and shola forests** at 1,200–2,600 m elevation, thriving on grassy slopes and rocky cliffs of the Western Ghats.
  - The **Eravikulam National Park (ENP)** in Kerala hosts the largest population, with smaller populations in the Palani Hills, Srivilliputtur, Meghamalai, and Agasthiyar Ranges.
- **Behaviour & Life Cycle** : A **diurnal species(active in the day)** , with a lifespan extending up to ~9 years in the wild.
- **Conservation Status:**
  - **IUCN Status** : Endangered
  - **WPA, 1972:** Schedule-I
- **Threats** : **Habitat loss** (deforestation, hydroelectric projects, monoculture), **livestock competition** , **poaching** , and **local extinction** (e.g., Karnataka highlands).
  - **Project Nilgiri Tahr was** launched in **October 2023** , focusing on **habitat management, population monitoring and scientific conservation.**
- **Ecological Significance** : Forms part of the prey base for large carnivores like leopard (and occasionally tiger), coexists with endemic species like the **Nilgiri langur** and **lion-tailed macaque** , and acts as an indicator of montane grassland health.



Read more: **Nilgiri Tahr - Drishti IAS**

Israel Airlifts Bnei Menashe from India

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Source: IE

Recently, Israel flew around 240 individuals from Mizoram to Tel Aviv under " **Operation Wings of Dawn"** amid ongoing security concerns in **West Asia** .

- This was the first of multiple batches with settlement planned in absorption centres such as **Nof HaGalil in northern Israel.**
- India clarified that it did not facilitate the operation, limiting its role to ensuring **legal migration and preventing trafficking.**

Bnei Menashe Community

- The **Bnei Menashe (meaning "sons of Manasseh")** claim descent from one of the **Ten Lost Tribes of Israel** , exiled around **722 BCE after the Assyrian conquest** .
- They are primarily part of **Mizo and Kuki tribal groups** , with a population of about **7,000 in Northeast India** . Their migration belief traces a journey through **Persia (Iran), Afghanistan, and into Northeast India** over centuries.
- Originally, most of the community had converted to Christianity under missionary influence, before a Judaising movement emerged in the late 20th century, shaped by local beliefs and organisations such as **Amishav and Shavei Israel.** By the 1980s, many had adopted Jewish practices.
- In 2005, Israel's Chief Rabbinate recognised them as a **"Lost Seed of Israel",** based on cultural claims and inconclusive genetic evidence, enabling phased migration.
  - Migration takes place through **Aliyah (return migration),** supported by agencies like the Jewish Agency for Israel (JAFI) and Israeli government programmes.
- Despite relocation, the community has faced **integration challenges** and instances of discrimination in Israel.

Read more: India-Israel Relations

Right to Safe Travel on National Highways under Article 21

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Source: TH

The **Supreme Court** has declared that the **safety of commuters against road accidents and the right to safe passage on highways** are part of the **fundamental right to life under Article 21 of the Constitution.**

- **Alarming Statistics:** National Highways (NHs) **comprise merely 2% of India's total road network but account for nearly 30% of all road fatalities** , highlighting severe infrastructural and administrative vulnerability.
- **Constitutional Interpretation:** The Court held that **Article 21 imposes a positive obligation on the State to ensure a safe environment,** extending beyond protection from unlawful death; fatalities due to avoidable hazards reflect failure of this duty.
- **Immediate Prohibitions:** The Court issued an immediate ban on the construction or operation of any new commercial structures, dhabas, or eateries within the **right-of-way of any National Highway** .
- **Strict Parking Regulations:** Heavy and commercial vehicles are strictly prohibited from parking or stopping on any **National Highway, carriageway, or paved shoulder** , except at officially designated lay-bys and wayside amenities to prevent blind-spot collisions.
- **Enforcement Actions:** District Magistrates have been directed to **demolish or remove all unauthorized structures within 60 days** .
  - Furthermore, no licenses or trade approvals within highway safety zones can be granted without prior clearance from the **National Highway Authority of India (NHAI)** or the Public Works Department (PWD).
- **Institutional Mechanism:** A **'District Highway Safety Task Force'** must be constituted in every district nationwide to monitor and enforce highway safety protocols.

Read more: Transforming India's Road Safety Landscape **,**